Policy & Strategy Lab

Capstone Guide

The capstone is the case, finished. It brings together twenty days of work on one Indian policy problem into a recommendation that a named decision-maker could act on, defended in front of a panel.

1. The five parts

Part	Form	Weight	Due
Client report	3,500 to 4,500 words plus annexes	20%	72 hours after Day 20
Full deck	10 to 12 slides, submitted	Assessed with the presentation	Draft at Gate 4 (Day 19); final with the report
Presentation	5 slides in 6 minutes	Part of 15%	Day 20
Individual defence	6 minutes of questions	Part of 15%	Day 20
Reflection	500 words on the sealed Day 3 answer	Assessed with the report	With the report

The pod synthesis slide (5 per cent) is presented jointly on Day 20. The evidence register (15 per cent) is submitted with the report. The workbook portfolio (35 per cent) is assessed after submission.

2. The client report

Write to your decision-maker, not to an examiner. The report should be readable in its first page alone, and checkable in full.

Section	Contents	Suggested length
Title and question	The decision the report informs	One line
Executive summary	Recommendation first; why; what it costs; what it depends on; the decision required	Up to 400 words
1. The problem and the decision	Problem statement, scope, why it matters, competing framings	400
2. Diagnosis	Structure of the problem, causes and mechanisms, the loop that sustains it, institutions, money, delivery chain and actors	900
3. Evidence and findings	Hypothesis verdicts, the strongest rival explanation, what the evidence does and does not establish	800
4. Options and appraisal	Options and baseline, criteria and weights, scores with reasons, cost per outcome, sensitivity	700
5. Recommendation	What, by whom, by when, at what cost; the public value test; what it gives up and for whom	400
6. Delivery and measurement	Theory of change and assumptions, decision rights, delivery approach, main risks, indicators and review points	700

Section	Contents	Suggested length
7. Limitations	What the analysis could not establish, and how that could change the recommendation	200
References	Chicago Notes and Bibliography	Not counted

Annexes (not counted in the word limit). A, issue tree and pruning matrix. B, problem tree and causal loop diagram. C, delivery chain, funding map and stakeholder matrix. D, evidence register. E, options appraisal with sensitivity. F, implementation plan and indicator framework.

Rules. Every figure has a year and a source. Language matches the strength of the evidence. No invented data. AI use is disclosed. Length is not rewarded: a tight 3,600-word report beats a padded 4,500-word one.

A model executive summary (spine case, illustrative)

Recommendation. The Commissioner should fund a partnership with a waste pickers' cooperative to collect and sort dry waste in ten pilot wards from the next financial year, including informal settlements, and should make payment for separated collection a condition of the main collection contract at its renewal next year.

Why. Most Madhyapur households hand over mixed waste, contrary to the 2016 rules. The evidence points to collection rather than awareness: households stop separating when they see crews tip separated bags together, and crews mix waste because the contract pays by weight. Distributing bins alone barely changed behaviour, and fines without monitoring increased roadside dumping.

Cost and value. The pilot costs about Rs 3 crore a year (illustrative), roughly Rs 860 per additional household separating, the lowest of the options appraised. It also brings informal waste pickers into recognised, safer work.

What it depends on. Above all, the cooperative's capacity to scale. If it reaches only half the pilot wards, the cost per household roughly doubles. The pilot is designed to test this, with a decision at the first quarterly review.

Decision required. Approve the pilot budget and authorise negotiation with the cooperative now, so that the contract terms can be settled before renewal.

3. The full deck (10 to 12 slides)

Every slide title is a full sentence that states the slide's claim. Read the titles alone: they should tell the whole story.

Slide	Content
1	Executive recommendation and the decision required
2	The problem and why it matters
3	How the problem was structured
4	Root causes and the loop that sustains the problem
5	Institutions, money and actors
6	Evidence and findings, with confidence
7	Options considered, and the baseline
8	Appraisal: criteria, weights and the choice
9	The recommended intervention and the public value test
10	Delivery: theory of change, roles and approach
11	Risks, indicators and review points
12	Next steps and the decision required

Use the Lab's visual style: white background, navy titles, restrained blue, small dots and fine rules; no stock photographs, clip art or decorative icons. Source every chart.

4. The five-slide pitch

Slide	Content	Time
1	The recommendation and the decision required	1 minute
2	The diagnosis: why the problem persists	1 minute
3	The evidence, and how confident you are	1.5 minutes
4	The choice: options, criteria and why this one	1.5 minutes
5	Delivery: plan, risks, indicators and the next step	1 minute

The remaining slides of the full deck are your back-up for the defence.

5. The reflection

Open the answer you sealed on Day 3. In 500 words: what changed between that answer and your recommendation; what did not; which piece of evidence or challenge caused each change; and what you would do differently with another four weeks. Changing your mind in response to evidence is assessed as a strength.

6. Running Day 20

6.1 The arithmetic

Each participant needs about 12 minutes (6 minutes of presentation, 6 of questions) plus a minute to change over. Allow about three minutes per pod for its synthesis slide.

Cohort	Presentation time	Recommended format
Up to 9	About 2 hours	One panel, within the session
12	About 2.6 hours	One panel; extend the session or use the second hour of Day 19
16	About 3.5 hours	Two parallel panels of about 1.75 hours each, or one extended session
20	About 4.3 hours	Two parallel panels; a second panel chair is needed

6.2 Run sheet (one panel, nine participants)

Time	Item
0:00	Panel briefing (before participants arrive)
0:05	Welcome and order of presentations
0:10	Presentations and defence, pod by pod
1:40	Pod synthesis slides
1:52	Sealed answers returned; five minutes to read
1:57	Close: deadlines for the report and reflection

6.3 Panel briefing

Role	Who	Focus
Decision-maker (chair)	Instructor or guest	Would I act on this? What exactly am I being asked to decide?
Finance officer	Guest panellist	Cost, value, who pays
Implementing official	Guest panellist	Staff, powers, capacity, delivery risk
Citizen representative	A participant from another pod	Who gains, who pays, who was left out

Rules for panellists. One question each, then follow-ups. No speeches. Firm, not hostile. The chair keeps time, shows a card at five minutes, and stops the presentation at six. Score on the presentation and defence rubric (Assessment Handbook, section 4.5) immediately after each defence, independently, then agree.

7. Defence question bank

Panellists choose questions that probe each participant's weakest domain. The instructor can flag these from the Analyst Development Tracker.

Framing (A)

1. Why this problem, rather than a neighbouring one?
2. Why this decision-maker? Does this role have the authority your recommendation needs?
3. What did you deliberately leave out of scope, and could it change your answer?
4. How would the most affected group state this problem? Is that different from your statement?

Structure and causes (B, C)

5. What splitting logic did you use, and why does it suit the decision?
6. Which branch did you prune that you are least comfortable about?
7. What is the mechanism behind your main causal claim?
8. What keeps this problem in place year after year?
9. What did earlier interventions miss?

Institutions and actors (D)

10. Who legislates, who administers and who pays for this service?
11. Where in the delivery chain does it break, and how do you know?
12. Who would lose from your recommendation, and can they block it?
13. What will the frontline worker actually do with this on a busy day?

Evidence and hypotheses (E, F)

14. What evidence contradicts your diagnosis?
15. Which rival explanation is strongest, and why did you set it aside?
16. Which of your sources is weakest, and what rests on it?
17. Is your key finding representative of your place, or only of the places studied?
18. Where are you confusing an association with a cause?
19. Which hypothesis did the evidence weaken, and what did you do about it?

Options and choice (G)

20. Why are these three options genuinely different?
21. Why did you weight the criteria as you did? Would the decision-maker agree?
22. What does the baseline look like, and why is your option better?
23. What would change your recommendation?
24. What does your cost per outcome depend on?
25. What does your recommendation give up, and for whom?
26. Would a smaller first step be wiser?

Delivery and measurement (H)

27. Which assumption in your theory of change is most likely to fail?
28. Who decides, who must agree, and who could block the key decision?
29. Why plan in full rather than pilot, or the reverse?
30. What would make implementation fail in the first six months?
31. How will we know within six months whether it is working?
32. Which of your indicators could be met while the problem stays unsolved?

Communication and judgement (I, J)

33. In one sentence, what are you asking me to decide?
34. Where is your evidence thinner than your slide suggests?
35. Is there a policy window for this now? If not, what would open one?
36. What did you change your mind about during the course?
37. What would you need to know to be more confident?
38. If I fund only half of this, what should I fund?
39. What is the first thing you would do on Monday morning?
40. What question did you hope we would not ask?

8. Submission checklist

Item	Done
Client report, 3,500 to 4,500 words, recommendation in the first paragraph	
Annexes A to F	
Final deck, 10 to 12 slides, argument titles	
Evidence register, every citation verified against the original	
Reflection on the sealed answer, 500 words	
AI-use disclosure	
Submitted within 72 hours of the end of Day 20	